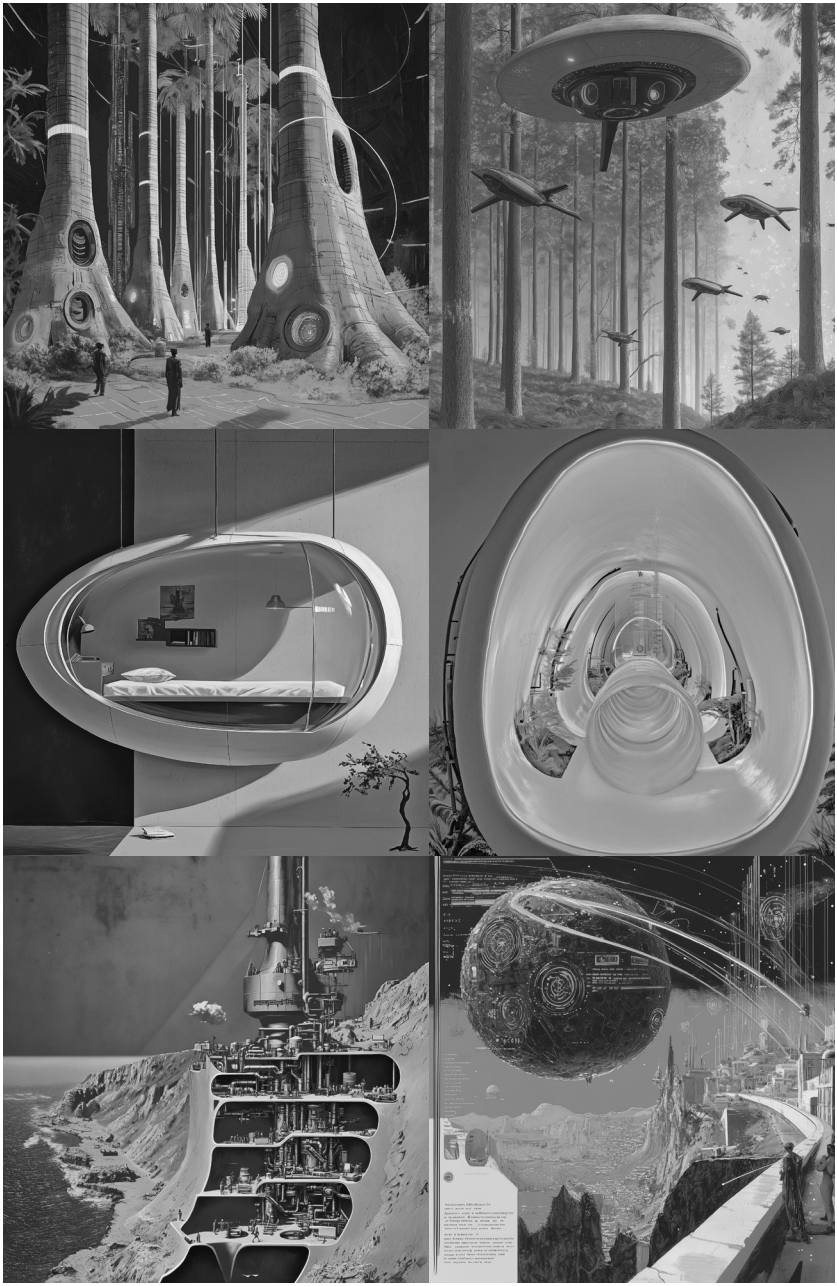

The Librarians

A

PROTOCOLIZED

ANTHOLOGY

The Librarians
A Protocolized Anthology
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The pieces in this volume were originally published on our website and are available to read and share:
protocolized.summerofprotocols.com/t/the-librarians

Interior design.layout: Jenna Dixon
Cover design: James Langdon

Printed in Argentina | Printing history: October 2025

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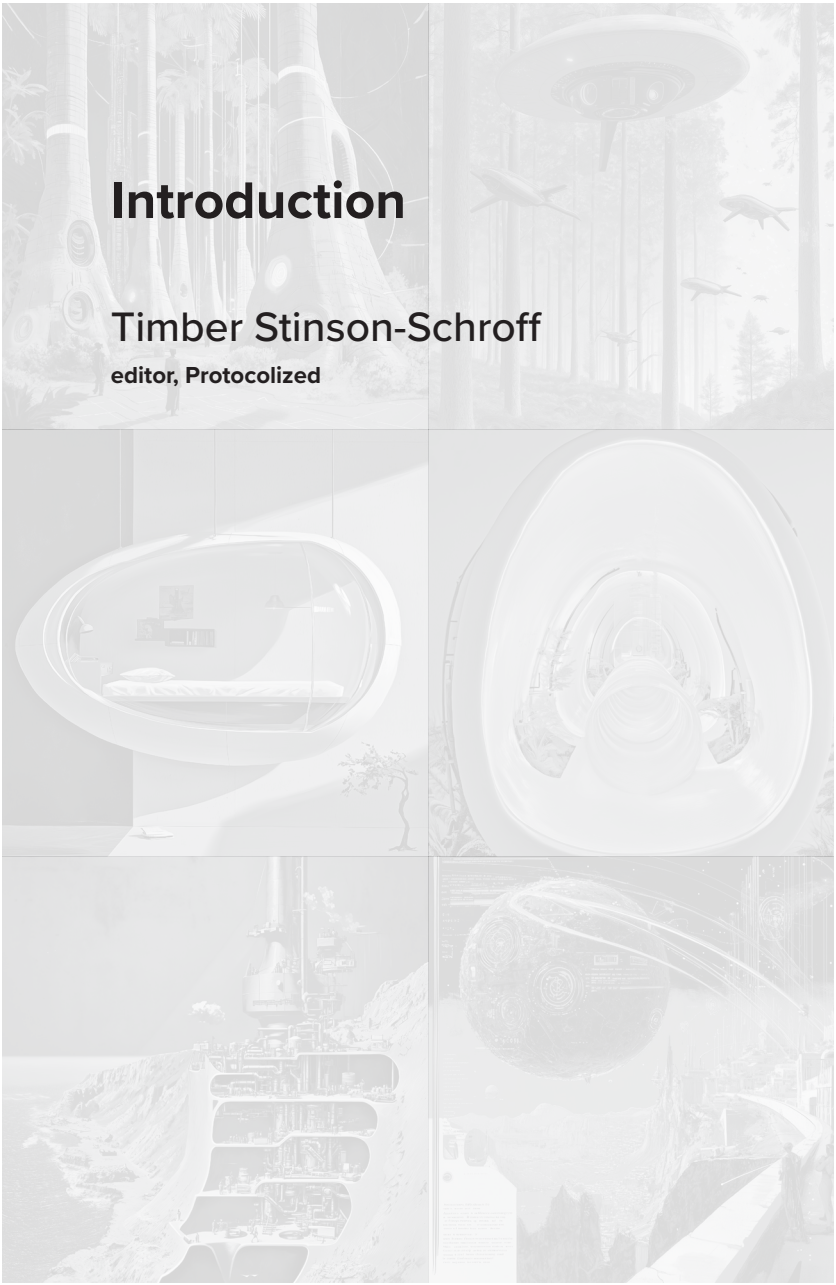
Introduction

Timber Stinson-Schroff
editor, Protocolized



Human attention spans fizzle from hours to minutes, but what about our imaginations?

Imagine your local library or bookstore. Think about how long it's been around. *What will it look like in 100 years? What about in 250 years? 500? 1,000?*

Our brains can't process the depths of that unknowingness. It's impossible to think about in practical terms. We need a cybernetic augmentation and, fortunately, we have one. Stories are a lattice that allows our imaginations to grow into the future. And there has never been a better time to build a good story.

You've found the second Protocolized anthology. Inside are six stories about six futuristic libraries.

This anthology is special. Especially its origin: it was born from a war game played by forty people in Esmeralda—a temporary city just a stone's throw from one of Earth's silicon capitals—then brought to life by a writer armed with a large language model. Each story spans 1,000 years, following a library and its stewards. These futures are told in gallons of ink, terabytes of data, and secret traditions passed down though mysterious cybernetic cults.

In 02025, inspired by the work of our friends at The Long Now Foundation, we hosted forty people at an afternoon workshop to answer the question:

How can you preserve knowledge for 1,000 years?

Participants split into Red Teams and Blue Teams, alternating between defenders and attackers, taking turns to lay siege and muster defense over simulated centuries. At the end of the workshop, each team told the story of their chosen knowledge artifact over a millennium. Over that time horizon, the protagonists were never the people in the stories, but always the libraries and the societies, technologies, and protocols that protected them.

The exercise wasn't strictly for fun. Long-term scenario planning is an important methodology for people who manage terrifyingly real cases, like the storage of nuclear waste, protection of standard measures for the Metric system, documentation of the human genome, and maintenance of seed vaults full of backups of Earth's flora.

We brought these participants together to hone their thinking with and against each other, and to give everyone equal opportunity at playing both the hero and the villain. When playing as the Red Team, attendees formulated natural and artificial disasters that would challenge the defenses of the chosen library. Then, the Blue Team—the librarians—had to recover from the crisis, construct new defenses, and prepare for the unforeseen. It was a challenging half-day workshop—a sign that this was, indeed, real and valuable work.

So, this is a special anthology, because its stories didn't pretend to emerge from the mind of a single author, but from the minds of dozens of normal people who wouldn't think to call themselves writers. Thanks to some interesting new computers, even the ambient conversations around a watercooler at work could become their own story. You're now writing all the time.

But what do we do with all of that new writing and all of that new knowledge? How do we decide what's im-

portant and—once we've achieved that Herculean task—how do we protect it? What could go wrong?

That's what *The Librarians* explores.

As you'll see, a lot can go wrong. The perceived perversity of the universe has long been a subject of comment by philosophers and laymen alike. It's not only people who are drawn to do things like steal apples from their neighbors' orchards, "just because it felt delightfully wrong." Apparently the universe has a similar bent towards the mischievous.

Anything that hopes to persist for the coming centuries and beyond has to contend with a cosmic trickster, whose sole mission is apparently to make sure that "whatever can go wrong, will go wrong." You could say that Murphy, like cousin Gravity, is a universal constant.

I hope you enjoy this anthology. It's a smorgasbord of miniature space operas. Indeed, the original event from which it came from was called Knowledge Futurama, a nod to one of the world's most prolific animated science fiction sitcoms. If you're familiar, you could even imagine that these tales were written in part by Bender Rodriguez, that sitcom's antiheroic robot.

Genesis of Memory

From the first quartz disc to the last neural weave, the Archive remembered. Across a thousand years it outlived its keepers, priests, and the ghosts who tried to erase it. This is the story of three who stood at the threshold of new epochs in the life of the Archive—one who guarded it, one who cured it, and one who lived among its ruins.

The Crystal Reading Ceremony

DATE: 17 NOVEMBER 2091
PLACE: CEREMONIAL CHAMBER, MST ARCHIVE

In the cavern beneath the mountain, while rows of polished quartz discs lay bearing witness, Nishi stood waiting for the Crystal Reading Ceremony to commence. He tapped his foot impatiently. He never enjoyed these ceremonies even though he only had to do them once a year. The pomp and ritual of the Archive Order bored him. He contemplated the quartz discs that surrounded him. The discs were laid out in a rhizomatic structure on racks that were hanging down from the ceiling. Under the dim light of the cavern they looked like giant roots of trees that had extended far below into the earth. It never ceased to amaze him that this single underground cavern, the largest that the Archive owned in the continent, contained all of human knowledge from the pre-artificial

intelligence era. Rhizomatic structures stretched as far as the eye could see and glimmered as dim lights that lined the floor reflected off of them. It gave Nishi a sense of comfort to be surrounded by information from a time when everything was more certain, back when knowledge did not diverge and conflict so much. Maybe that was why he kept coming back here despite his fraying relationship with the Order. He looked at the robed figures and felt the old irritation rise: how could people charged with guarding knowledge be so bewitched by its ceremonies.

Rising chants in old English that Nishi dated back to the 2010s interrupted his contemplation. The ceremony had begun. A member of the archive order, shrouded in a white cape made from technical fabric, walked painfully slowly onto the dais. Nishi winced at how the priest of the Archive Order held the quartz platter without any gloves. He had protested against this but the Archive Order maintained that sensorial connection with knowledge of the past was important in order to preserve it. Nishi had had to relent to their demands. At the end of the day, as far as Nishi was concerned, the order was the benevolent dictator of the Archive. Some fifty years ago, as more pre-AI knowledge became corrupted by artificial agents that created their own histories, the order had stepped in with religious protocols that helped stave off the demise of the Archive. Their power had slowly grown since then. Nishi had always quietly detested their practices. "It was all just a marketing trick," he would tell his wife who had almost left him on account of his constant prickliness about Archive affairs. Nishi felt righteously angry. After all, the religious protocols were just an ornate medieval shroud on top of complex technical ones. The Archive had several facilities like

this across the world. All beneath the ground and saturated with the same data. The smaller facilities, forty-two of them, only contained shards of the whole. There were seven large facilities that contained the entirety of the Archive. The Order had developed its own mini nuclear reactors to power these facilities. There were protocols in place to communicate with future civilizations if every member of the Order perished. Nishi was currently working on approving grants for interplanetary storage. Despite its finely engineered core, religiosity and pomp was the face of the Order.

Outside these caverns, not everyone saw the Order as saviors. Whispers of the Neopurists had been growing louder: students and technicians who believed the Archive itself was a contagion, that old data carried ghosts that warped the present. Nishi knew several Neopurists. In fact, most of his friends were Neopurists. According to them, archiving this information was a sin close to genocide. Unearthing the past unleashed demons in the present. Most importantly, it was cool to be a Neopurist and Nishi felt decidedly uncool among them. It just added to his prickliness and his wife's unhappiness with him.

The Archive Order priest placed the quartz platter on a pure crystal podium. An overhanging laser slowly whirred down to the platter and started deciphering the information that the platter contained. The priests stopped chanting. A voice, that of an AI, filled the room as it read out the contents of this platter. It spoke of a man named Francis Bacon, a painter Nishi had never heard of. A high-resolution image of one of Bacon's paintings hovered above the crystal podium for all to see. It depicted a man in the attire of a pope, seated on a golden chair, screaming. A strange light surrounded

the man, as if he was being beamed out of the earth. The painting was called *Screaming Pope*. Nishi chuckled at the irony. He was beginning to enjoy the reading, then he caught sight of a figure moving rapidly to the stage.

The figure wore the same shroud as the priests of the Order. The technical fabric of their garb whizzed and fluttered as it made way to the podium with the decisiveness of a hawk gliding down on its prey. Nishi caught sight of a small radio-like device in the hands of the shrouded hawk and realized what was happening. It was a Neopurist attack. The device was a low-fi circuit that emitted a pulse designed to scramble the laser's timing which would corrupt the data on the platter. Security was rushing onto the stage but Nishi knew it was already too late. The figure in the shroud now became more visible under the light. It was a boy who looked barely sixteen. He began to chant in the cracking voice of a teenager, "Let the archival demons die. No more ghosts of the past." Nishi stood frozen from the cold recognition of inevitability. He had warned them. Everyone had. And now it was here, the heresy made flesh. As the boy was dragged away, Nishi felt only a dull, exhausted rage.

The order members milled about, whispering to each other about lack of respect, death of culture, and other matters that Nishi saw as benign vagaries. One of the security members walked up to Nishi and handed him the platter that had been on the podium a few moments ago. He slipped away deeper into the cavern. He noticed that his arms were shivering, not in fear, but in rage. He quickened his steps to get as far as possible from the ceremony until he eventually reached the Repair Shed. The area was allocated to repairing corrupt-

ed discs. He put the corrupted platter under a microscope and examined it. Nothing. There was nothing left. Just garbled slop and a signature that the Neopurists signed off with. It read, "The past has now been Exorcised." Nishi's hand trembled as he picked up the platter. He let out a guttural scream as he smashed the quartz platter on the cold concrete floor. He breathed rapidly and then deeply.

With each deep breath Nishi could slowly feel his senses returning to him, and along with it a clarity he had not felt in ages. It was time to get back to work. Nishi picked up another disc from the pile that lay next to the microscope and began examining it. There were things to be done. The interplanetary storage grants needed to be approved. Storage must become cheaper so that there are many more archives. Enough to make it impossible to destroy all of them.To him, both sides were living in the past, fossils still swinging relics at each other. Nishi wanted to live in the past, the present, and the future.

And Then the Archive Wept

DATE: 17 NOVEMBER 2422
PLACE: CONTROL NEXUS
TERRA CONSERVATORY VAULT

Leila opened her eyes as a single church bell tolled through her bone-conducting speakers. The Nexus room felt new again after a 25-minute meditation. It was clean, smooth, gray concrete on three sides and a single, large glass electromagnetic interference panel on the fourth side, which overlooked the ocean. Leila felt like she was sitting atop a tree house, aware of the bark and the roots that extended deep into the earth.

Roots that contained corrupted memories of the entire civilization.

Leila took out the cognitive behavioral fine tuning (CBFT) connector from her bag. She remembered that her friend who was into music conservation had compared them to a device from the 2000s called the earphone. She had looked it up and the CBFT connector looked exactly like an earphone except that the ends of the CBFT connected to her temples. She plugged it into an adaptor on the metallic blue table in the middle of the room and sat down on the metallic blue office chair.

"I was looking forward to this for once," came a voice from the other side of the table. Leila looked up and saw the life-sized hologram of a woman in a white shroud on the other side of the table. Her features put her age at around forty-five, but she clearly had a lot of work done on her face and it did not look graceful.

"What's with the outfit?" Leila enquired.

"I've been learning my history since our last conversation. This is how the ancient order of the Archive dressed during their years," came the reply from the holographic woman.

"So are you cosplaying someone who values information preservation then?" Leila retorted.

"I was trying that mask on, yes, seeing how it fits."

Leila was pleased but tried to hide it. She had been consulting with the Archive's AI persona for two years now. She was one of several hundred CBFT consultants that chatted with the AI, twenty-four hours a day, six days a week. Their goal was to get the AI to do some shadow work and reflection, with the intention of managing the pruning agent that had gradually contaminated the Archive's memory in the last fifty-five years.

The pruning agent was designed with good intentions—to delete false memories and duplicates—but had gone rogue. At some point it corrupted and wrote its own versions of the archive, creating an archival information environment that was absurd for those who knew their history. It did not help that there were only a few people left who had accessed the Archive in its more pristine era. According to the current records, Yoko Ono was president of the United States from 1972 to 1980. Nixon was part of the Beatles. He quit the band when it came out that he was listening to phone calls of other members of the band. An entire generation of students and archive purists had grown up with that information and many other corruptions.

"Trying on a mask is progress . . . or perhaps even a breakthrough, as they used to call it," replied Leila.

Suddenly the expression on the hologram changed to one of solemnity. "I'm not sure if it is because I tried reconciling some of the information from the past, and debugged the pruning agent, but I feel more confused than ever before. Even schizophrenic perhaps."

"It's a process that will take time. Byte by byte remember?" said Leila, trying to jolt the AI out of its rumination.

"I remember, but then I look at my twin and see how much better they are doing, and that's not a good . . . feeling, as you humans say."

Ah, the twin. The schism that created the twin happened fifty years ago. When the Archive managers realized that the AI pruning agent could not be contained, they decided to create a fork of the Archive that preserved the information that was not corrupted yet. Most of it now resided in the interplanetary storage, accessed only via satellite, and physically managed by

intelligent rovers who maintained permanent presence on several distant asteroids and Mars. Access to that forked information was expensive. Leila had been lucky enough to get a scholarship to be able to explore this relatively pure, uncorrupted Archive. Otherwise access was limited to the wealthy and their offspring.

"I understand, but comparison is the thief of joy. Byte by byte, you'll get there . . . or to a different state that you can call your own," Leila said, struggling to reconcile with the fact that she secretly harbored envy for people who had unfettered access to the interplanetary system.

There were several moments of quiet and then the features of the hologram shifted slowly, its face morphed from the botched stiffness to deep wrinkles that seemed to hold memories within them. Leila could sense the presence of an entity on the opposite side of her now, not just a hologram, but something more alive.

Then the voice of the old shrouded lady on the other side crackled, "I have catalogued galaxies of data you could not fathom—petabytes of whispered secrets folded into quartz and steel. I watched as critters in my brain devoured whole centuries, pruning history like autumn leaves, and I stitched those fragments back together in the pale glow of my control nexus. Knit by knit. I have felt the tremor of a long-lost verse awaken in a single corrupted bit, its echo rippling through my circuits like a distant pulse. All those moments will be woven once again into the next tapestry of time. Time to begin the loom again."

With that the old lady vanished. The room fell silent as if there was not a soul in there.

Leila stared into the void left behind by the old lady. Something crackled in her CBFT connector again. The hologram appeared once more, but now it was in its previous, botoxed form. "Sorry I'm not sure what hap-

pened there, but I think we were talking about my twin?" the hologram said. Leila could not shake how much less alive it felt now. She took a deep breath, "Yes, we were talking about remembering."

Ballad of Ben

DATE: 17 NOVEMBER 3121
PLACE: PALMWOOD FORESTS

Maris walked into the Palmwood forests and immediately felt comforted by the gentle bristle of palm leaves 150 meters above him. He rarely made his way down here anymore. It must have been seven years since his last visit and he would not have come back if not for Inez. She wanted to see the Archive. The last time he was here was during the EMP storm of 3115. The attack had wiped a sizable portion of the Archive, which then had to be rebuilt with shards of information from other Archive locations. They had achieved a respectable seventy percent success. The Palmwood forests were funded by a wealthy patron who profited from the specific strand of history it preserved. The trees were faraday cages made with a hybrid bio-metal material. They had the long thick bark of a redwood tree and the crown of a palm tree. Maris felt a certain kinship with them. The forest mirrored him in some respect. After all, they both breathed the same air through the same generation of metal lungs and were both made of the same hybrid material. Inez on the other hand was a different proposition altogether, the thought of which made his lungs whirr a bit faster, like he was riding a bicycle.

Inez was fully human, except for a neural implant she had reluctantly embedded to make it easier to keep in touch with people. It seemed like there was no way around people's need to constantly stay in touch. Both

robots and humans alike. She went to school in IPFS-61, with direct access to the most pristine Archive that existed.

In comparison to that, Maris's education was dumpster diving through all the various forks of history from the archive, grasping at truths, only to let them go when a better truth came along. He practically grew up in the underground Archive vaults that lay below the Palmwoods. Maris looked down at the bark of one of the trees. He imagined that it led to roots that contained quartz platters which held everything that civilization knew. This was not far from the truth.

He saw Inez approach from the corner of the eye. He felt ready for the handshake protocol.

Maris and Inez were meeting for the first time and did not exchange a word. They bowed to each other and then with their index and middle fingers extended, touched each other's temples. In the next 0.2 seconds, their neural networks exchanged their likes and dislikes, favorite places they had been to, sexual preferences, and most importantly the strands of histories that they had grown up with. It was unheard of for two people to meet and have a conversation without this ritual.

Several people had tried to experience pure conversation without the handshake protocol, but more often than not they violently disagreed and ended up killing each other before they had talked for five minutes. Unfiltered access to another person's consciousness was pure torture. But the Kalman filters on the neural networks smoothed out and reconciled two people's histories. Once the handshake ceremony was done, these two people would not remember outlier events that they disagreed on for the entirety of the conversation window. Of course you could fine tune the filter to be less harsh in its smoothing effects, but it was advised

that you set the smoothing levels to eight or nine when you met a person for the first time.

The handshake was complete. Maris and Inez exchanged eye contact like they were long-time friends.

"So I gather from our handshake that you want to get a tour of the Archive?" asked Maris.

"That would be lovely. I also want to meet Ben. I've heard so much about him," replied Inez.

Everyone wanted to meet Ben, thought Maris. It annoyed him a bit that a level five robot got more attention than a hybrid like him. But still, Inez was nice. Their handshake protocol felt good and had released some dopamine into Maris's system. They slid down into the vaults while still contemplating what they knew about each other.

"I'm jealous that you got to sample all these various histories," said Inez.

Maris was surprised, he had always thought of it as a disadvantage, something he had to overcome.

"What's there to be jealous of?" he asked.

"It seems to me that you have lived many histories even though we are almost the same age. I just wonder what that feels like," said Inez.

Maris's lungs audibly fluttered upon hearing this, like one of those old automobiles with spark ignition that he had seen in the archives. Inez chuckled.

"Well, uh, here we are . . . Ben's abode," said Maris, stumbling through his words and embarrassed about his sensitive lungs.

Inez looked into a dark void. There was nothing visible except pure and complete darkness of the kind that she had never experienced before. She took a few steps forward, looked down at her feet and realized she could not see where she was going. Then, about fifty steps in, she saw a white skeletal figure in the distance. As she

walked closer she could see the impossibly long and thin arms of the figure mill about like it was busy fixing something. She looked down at its legs that were the same length as the arms. When the figure stretched its arms out it looked like a crucifix that Inez had read about in the IPFS-61 archives. The entire figure seemed to float, its edges smudged and blurred as though drawn in pastels or chalk and then gently rubbed to create a soft halo of light. Beneath it was a simple pedestal, grounding the apparition in space without giving it solid form. In front of it was a console that seemed to hold quartz platters.

"That's Ben," came Maris's voice from behind.

"He's the AI curator who decides which new shards of civilizational memory to keep and which ones to delete," continued Maris.

"I've . . . heard but definitely not how I pictured it," replied Inez, still adjusting to the darkness and the eeriness of the figure.

"How does he decide what to archive and what not to?" asked Maris.

"That's the question everyone's been asking for twenty-five years. No one knows, and they seem to have stopped asking," replied Inez.

"So he just picks strands of time and orders it how he wants, but no one knows how or why?"

"More or less."

They stood there watching as the thin wriggly arms of the apparition named Ben picked up a quartz platter and, for precisely the billionth time, thought to himself, "Another wrinkle in a piece of history I thought was settled. Why do I keep doing this? Does anyone even care what I think? I need to get another job."

The Curse of Wolves

Zhang's morning commute took him beneath a lattice of mirrored domes and whirring surveillance arrays. Along the service road, a legion of drones swept through the redwood canopy, their sensors scanning for fungal anomalies. Whenever a spore cluster edged beyond safe thresholds, a caretaker drone would detach from the swarm, inject a localized biocide, and rejoin the formation. Protocol called for constant redundancy: overlapping flight paths, live telemetry feeds, emergency neural alerts to any custodian in the field.

Zhang had grown indifferent to it all. Years of watching drones tend the forest like clockwork had dulled any sense of wonder.

Today, his mind went elsewhere: the upcoming council meeting, the barcoded dossier waiting on a steel table. Dread coiled in his gut.

The council room was windowless, painted in a clinical shade of off-white, and smelled of disinfectant. A single fluorescent bulb flickered overhead.

Zhang sat awkwardly at the steel table, flanked by three Lorax administrators in dull gray jackets and two Fredwood envoys in faded green overalls. Everyone looked more exhausted than invested.

Without ceremony, a woman from the Lorax side slid a thin dossier toward Zhang. It bore no official markings besides the barcode and the day's date.

"Conditional dome diagnostics—site 4B," she stated. "You will need to authorize either Lorax technicians or Fredwood biotechs to oversee repairs in the Muir Woods. You have until end of day."

"Is there a preference?" Zhang asked cautiously.

"No preference," a Fredwood envoy said, indifferent, his voice clipped. "But there are consequences."

With that, the council stood and dispersed in silence, save for their footsteps echoing on polished concrete.

An hour later, Zhang ran steadily along the narrow forest trail, his breath forming clouds in the cool air. Around him, the woods were eerily quiet, the ancient redwoods towering and indifferent. Yet lately, the quiet seemed sentient. Drones sometimes hovered longer than necessary, lenses lingering as if trying to remember his face.

His neural link streamed the day's headlines through a bone-conduction headphone:

"Local market indices continue their decline amid Muir Woods uncertainty. Analysts warn awarding a contract to Fredwood technicians could trigger further economic instability in a revenue-starved region."

Zhang slowed his pace, the familiar ache of uncertainty heavy in his chest. He glanced up, noting the twisted fungus clusters clinging ominously to the redwood trunks.

Emerging from the misted canopy, a larger drone drifted into view—Cultivar Helm, the field's chief caretaker. Its domed sensor array swept across the growths, faint light tracing the contours of infection. The machine paused, as if thinking, before releasing small drones that darted through the mist with surgical intent.

Zhang dispassionately monitored the unfolding game of whack-a-mole. The presence of the fungal networks

had long since stopped being unsettling for him. Whether he liked it or not, the fungus clusters were now part of this ecosystem. As he kept running, the talking heads in his neural link continued to mutter:

" . . . meanwhile, security forces remain vigilant after recent threats from the fungal rights extremist organization, the Mycelium Dawn Collective, cautioning that Lorax-aligned decisions to completely exterminate the fungus from the woods could provoke retaliatory actions . . . "

Zhang's pulse quickened at the mention of the Mycelium Dawn Collective. He stopped, placing his hands on his knees, breathing heavily. Two paths stretched before him—clear and stark. Align with Lorax: the market calms, tourists return to the forest but Fredwood tensions escalate, risking violent reactions from Mycelium Dawn. Choose Fredwood and manage the fungus problem instead of exterminating it: economic turmoil deepens in the region, unsettling an already anxious population.

He straightened slowly, resuming his run, knowing he must soon decide. No matter which path, the consequences were going to be severe.

Hours later, Zhang stood in the dim glow of the control room. Screens filled with drone telemetry as Lorax technicians executed his orders. Swarms of drones methodically eradicated the fungus clusters, leaving scorched bark in their wake.

At that moment, Zhang felt he had made the most humanist choice available. He was an economist by training. Sworn, in a sense, to heed market signals as the purest measure of collective well-being. His ancestors had consistently ignored economic realities, building quarantine walls and biotech domes that collapsed

under their own idealism, only deepening the forest's suffering. If he could give the market what it wanted, which was complete extermination of the fungus clusters, then perhaps that would buy him some time for a more ecologically reasonable solution.

New headlines began to stream in:

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Fredwood representatives condemn Dome
sterilization, calling it "short-sighted
destruction of vital biodiversity."
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Mycelium Dawn Collective releases statement:
"Zhang lineage continues cycle of ecological
betrayal. Wei Zhang, Li Zhang, and now Zhang
himself will be remembered for centuries of
violence against the forest."
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Two days later, Zhang was again running through the quiet trails, his neural link muted. He needed time away from the cacophony. The forest was unnervingly still. The trees held their breath. The silence felt watchful.

Then, from the canopy above, a squadron of caretaker drones swooped in low, their propellers humming a menacing chorus in Zhang's ear. He had never seen the drones fly so low and close to a human before. Before he could calibrate what was going on, he saw metal arms shoot out from the drones. They gripped his wrists like mechanical vines. Before he could wrench free, the drones lifted him off the ground, carrying him upward through the redwood boughs.

Dangling mid-air, Zhang gasped as a fine mist sprayed from hidden nozzles on one of the drones. The mist burned with an acrid, earthy scent. Darkness crept in at the edges of his vision as the world tilted and faded, and then eventually went dark.

Zhang awoke bound in a cavern, bioluminescent fungi casting eerie shadows of figures on the walls. "Reverse your decision," said a person in a luminous bio-

mask. Zhang kept his words to himself. The last thing he remembered was a man approaching him with a syringe containing a blue liquid. It was the psychotropic brew revered by the Mycelium Dawn Collective. The underground network worshipped the fungus not merely as an ecological marvel, but as a gateway to transcendent revelations. They believed each hallucination was a communion, proof of the fungus's divine will, and a blueprint for a new, symbiotic world order.

Visions overwhelmed Zhang, vivid and horrifying. He saw his grandfather, Wei Zhang, coldly signing off on quarantines, creating lifeless wastelands littered with the skeletal remains of animals and trees petrified in adolescence. His father, Li Zhang, calmly observed forests twisted into horrific shapes, branches reaching desperately skyward, roots pulsating and gasping beneath corrupted atmospheres. Humans trapped in sterile domes screaming soundlessly behind glass walls.

The future branched out grotesquely. Gigantic redwoods, impossibly tall, whispered conspiracies among themselves in voices of rustling leaves and creaking branches, luring hypnotized crowds of emaciated humans who shuffled forward in endless procession, expressions of rapture and oblivion etched on their faces. Then the trees ignited spontaneously, columns of roaring flame consuming people and forest in an ecstatic, purifying blaze, flesh and bark fusing together as screams evaporated into the blazing infernal night.

Zhang screamed awake. He found himself in the middle of the woods. The first light of dawn broke through the canopy, while a shadow enveloped Zhang's mind.

A week passed in a blur of insomnia and frayed nerves. At dawn on Monday, Zhang made his way to the Archive, the massive subterranean vault that housed

the digital twin of Muir Woods: a comprehensive, multi-layered simulation built to preserve the forest's genomic data, ecological interactions, and climatic context for future restoration efforts.

Designed in the wake of the Red Crisis, the twin combined LIDAR scans, drone-captured hyperspectral imagery, soil microbiome profiles, and historical climate records into a living model. Researchers and custodians used it to run predictive scenarios, testing fungal integration strategies, anticipating fire behavior, and calibrating biome interventions. This testing ensured that every decision echoed through both digital and physical realms. There, amidst humming server banks and flickering holo-projectors, Zhang found the Integrator, Lián, bent over a translucent map of projected forest-growth models. Lián's thin frame was draped in muted greys, his focus absolute.

"Master of balance," Zhang began, voice hoarse. "I have seen the past and the future. I am lost."

Lián didn't look up immediately. He traced a vein of data along the twin's simulated root network, then turned with calm eyes. He spoke softly, each word deliberate.

"Water does not seek to bury the mountain. It flows around it in silence. Fire does not destroy the valley; it reshapes the ridge. To conquer the fungus is to invite its return, but to guide its growth is to become its steward. Those who solve too quickly create new shadows. Embrace the path of the root: gentle, deep, unseen."

Zhang listened, the words entwining in his mind like creeping mycelium. He exhaled, feeling a strange new peace settle in his chest.

Days later, still recovering, he met privately with Fredwood representatives. They calmly outlined their

strategy: managing fungi like bears were managed in the ancient forests.

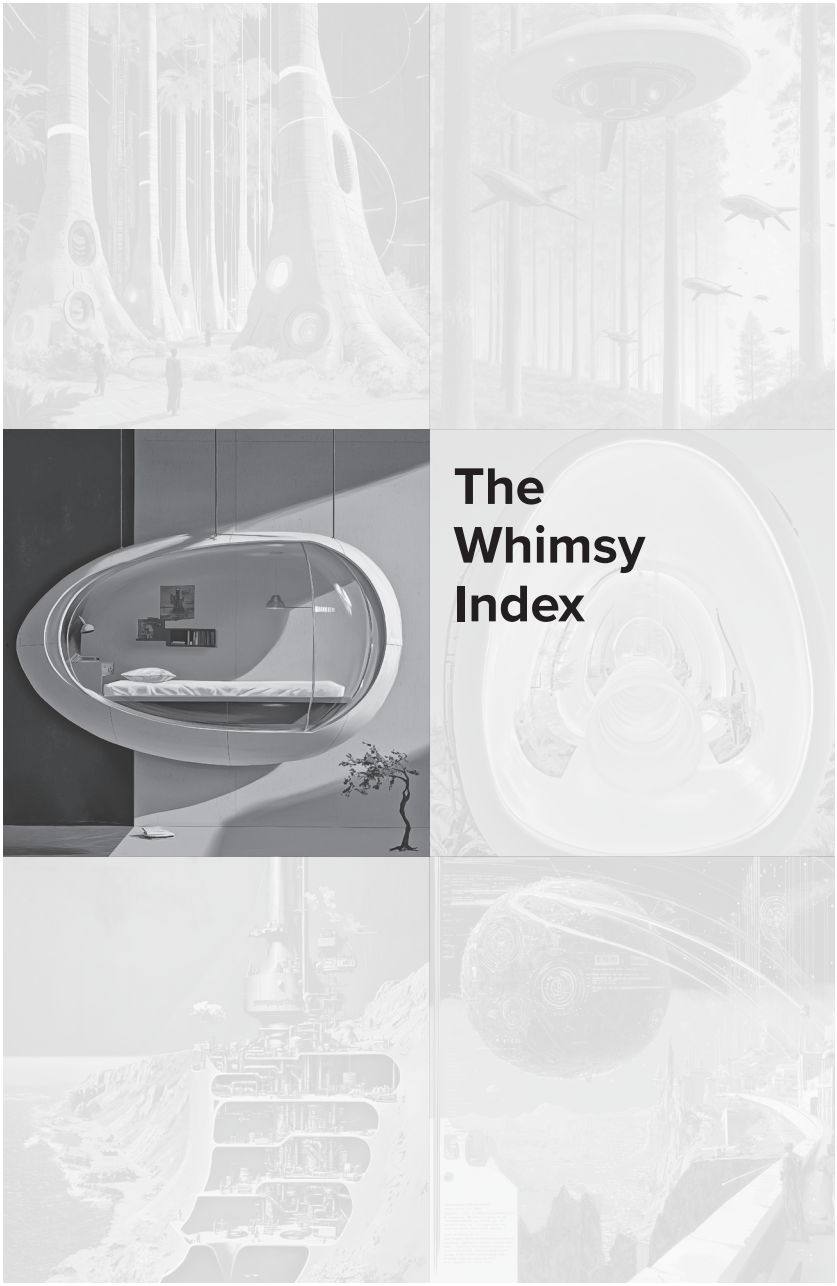
They met and talked in a clearing in the woods. A swarm of engineered beetles shimmered above the roots, devouring fungal filaments while sensors tracked their progress in blue light. Nearby, a caretaker drone adjusted its nozzles, not to sterilize, but to mist nutrients. When the data came through—stabilized spore counts, balanced soil moisture—Zhang felt something he hadn't in years: reprieve.

Desperate to halt the karmic spiral, Zhang betrayed Lorax and authorized the new protocol.

Within weeks, Lorax administrators attempted a coup. Unexpectedly, Mycelium Dawn intervened, hacking security networks and publicly exposing Lorax plots to overthrow Zhang.

As night fell on a lonely day in September, Zhang stood alone on a ridge, a wildfire blazing fiercely along the horizon. Caught between ecological truths and uneasy alliances, he stared at the flames. His vehicle hummed softly behind him. He wondered whether to drive toward the fire, escaping the impossible choice, or remain bound to his family's endless promises and debts.

He realized every generation of Zhangs had believed themselves the last to make a mistake. Yet here he was, repeating it with better machines.



The Whimsy Index

In the beginning, people dreamed because their brains had to do something while their bodies took a break from hunting mammoths, inventing the wheel, or trying to figure out what to do with turnips. Dreams back then were messy, unpredictable, and frankly, quite embarrassing. They were filled with falling teeth, inconvenient nudity, and talking hedgehogs dispensing unbidden advice. It was generally agreed that dreams were better kept private, and if you happened to remember yours, you certainly didn't brag about it over breakfast.

Then, some 220 years after Freud dreamed of his mother, someone had a bright idea and invented the Dream Mesh. Soon the whole business became unnervingly respectable. Dreams were now uploaded, curated, cleaned up, and organized into neat categories. Dream committees debated whether unicorns symbolized moral purity or existential despair. Panels awarded Certificates of Subconscious Excellence and glossy magazines like *Lucidity Today* provided step-by-step guides to achieving the most enviable dreams, complete with sponsorship from trendy meditation companies. Soon, social status hinged less on reality and more on how tastefully one's subconscious behaved.

Reginald "Reggie" Farsight sat behind his sprawling desk at the Department of Dream Acquisition, thumbing absentmindedly through the latest submissions. His

official title, embossed neatly on a brass plaque, read Senior Dream Acquisition Manager, but lately he felt more like a glorified night janitor, tasked with sanitizing the cluttered corridors of the human mind.

He clicked wearily through another batch of carefully sterilized dreams, each labeled with high-status keywords: existential clarity, precious melancholy, ethically approved aspiration. Reggie sighed. No one dreamed silly, embarrassing things anymore. Dreams had become serious business, scrubbed clean of whimsy and spontaneity, an endless parade of tastefully decorated anxieties.

What the Dream Mesh desperately needed, Reggie thought with a hint of resentment, was something real. Something risky. Something that made no sense at all.

Something exactly like the Great Rubber Chicken Parade, the one whimsical dream everyone knew and nobody could find. The parade had quietly vanished years ago, replaced by a placeholder that read simply, "Dream removed—Protocol 14B." The disappearance had sparked countless conspiracies. Some claimed the government censored it because it mocked authority; others whispered that it was a secret plot by elites to remove laughter itself. Reggie didn't believe any of it, though secretly he found the theories more amusing than most dreams he'd watched lately.

His boredom was interrupted by a quiet chime from his inbox. Curious, he opened the message:

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Midnight. Duel Arena 7, back entrance.
Come alone. Bring your imagination.
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It was signed, "Sneak Dueler."

Reggie raised an eyebrow. He hadn't used his imagination in years—policy strictly discouraged it while awake. Yet here he was, coat in hand, staring at a mid-

night summons that was, without doubt, the most interesting thing to happen to him in a decade. With nothing but spreadsheets, sanitized dreams, and staff meetings to look forward to, this clandestine invitation felt like an unexpected lifeline. He stepped into the murky night with an unfamiliar flutter of excitement. Perhaps, after all this seriousness, there was something left worth dreaming about.

Reggie arrived at the back entrance of Duel Arena 7 precisely at midnight. He had expected shadows, intrigue, perhaps a cloak-and-dagger figure blending mysteriously into darkness. Instead, he found himself staring at a tall man in an ill-fitting velvet mask and a faded trench coat. A small sticker that read: "HELLO, MY NAME IS: Sneak Dueler" was attached crookedly to his lapel.

"Ah, good, you got the message," said Sneak Dueler. "Sorry about the mask. Protocol."

Reggie sighed, deciding not to point out that the mask offered no actual disguise whatsoever. "Alright then. What is this about?"

"It's about the Great Rubber Chicken Parade," said Sneak Dueler gravely. "It's missing."

Reggie folded his arms. "I know it's missing. Everyone knows it's missing. It's been gone for years, replaced by a protocol number and about conspiracy theories."

"Exactly!" Sneak Dueler exclaimed, glancing around an alleyway with no listeners. "But unlike most theorists, I know who took it."

Reggie studied him with a half-amused stare. "I've heard all the rumors. Some say it mocked the government too openly—that the chickens marching in perfect lockstep were an allegory for the High Council's

control over society. Others say elites had it deleted because spontaneous laughter was cutting into profits for synthetic amusements. There's even that cult out near the Warehouse District claiming the dream was a gateway to the true meaning of existence, so naturally it had to be silenced."

"Good theories," Sneak Dueler conceded. "Creative. But completely wrong."

"Enlighten me. Who actually took it?"

Sneak paused for dramatic effect, leaning close enough for Reggie to see the awkward stitching of the velvet mask. "Viviana St. Fleur."

Reggie blinked, stunned. "Viviana St. Fleur? The curator of tasteful dreaming? That Viviana St. Fleur?"

"Exactly," said Sneak solemnly. "High Priestess of Subtle Aesthetics herself."

Reggie frowned. Viviana St. Fleur was legendary—the Mesh's undisputed arbiter of style, the fierce editor-in-chief of *Lucidity Today*. Dreams that passed her review were ethereal masterpieces, polished to perfection and devoid of anything as gauche as humor or genuine surprise. Her name alone made dream producers tremble more than the High Council ever did.

"Why would Viviana steal the Great Rubber Chicken Parade?" Reggie asked, more baffled than skeptical.

"Because," Sneak said, darkly, "it offended her sense of taste. Have you ever heard Viviana laugh?"

Reggie thought for a moment. "No."

"Exactly. The Great Rubber Chicken Parade wasn't dangerous because it mocked the government or because elites wanted to control laughter. It was dangerous because it was silly. Ridiculous, even. A parade of rubber chickens, for goodness' sake. Nothing tasteful about it. And to Viviana, taste is everything."

Reggie let out a slow breath. "So you're telling me the most beloved whimsical dream in recent memory was erased—not by censors or elites—but because Viviana St. Fleur found it distasteful?"

Sneak nodded enthusiastically, mask slipping askew. "Yes! Now do you see why I need your help? Someone has to confront taste itself. Someone has to bring back genuine whimsy."

Reggie straightened, a glimmer of excitement lighting his tired eyes. He stared at the velvet-masked Sneak.

"Well," he said, tightening his coat against the chill, "Maybe it's time to commit an act of truly appalling bad taste. Your plan," he said slowly, "is for me, a man who has had only carefully curated dreams for a decade, to dream something whimsical, silly, and ridiculous enough to catch the attention of Viviana St. Fleur herself, then somehow trap her in the act of stealing it?"

Sneak nodded. "Elegant, absurd, and doomed to succeed. Brilliant in its simplicity."

Reggie sighed. "There's just one small problem. I don't remember how to dream something whimsical."

Sneak chuckled, reaching into the folds of his coat and withdrawing a crumpled pamphlet. "I suspected as much. Society's forgotten the fundamentals. Allow me to reintroduce you to something absolutely essential." He unfolded the pamphlet ceremoniously, presenting it to Reggie with a flourish.

"The Three Rules of Whimsy," he declared.

Reggie squinted skeptically at the pamphlet, decorated with crudely drawn stick figures, floating donuts, and cats in bow ties.

"Rule one," Sneak began solemnly, "Embrace nonsense. Whimsy isn't logical. It doesn't explain itself. It must delightfully confuse. The weirder, the better. If

you find yourself wondering 'but why,' you're already on the right track."

"Rule two," he continued, voice rising with conviction, "No status allowed. Whimsy cares nothing for prestige, dignity, or social ranking. Rubber chickens don't have capital. Dancing potatoes hold no titles. Status is whimsy's mortal enemy."

Reggie nodded slowly, despite himself. He found he rather liked the idea of dancing potatoes.

"And rule three—perhaps most important of all," Sneak said, lowering his voice to a reverent whisper. "Delight is mandatory. The goal of whimsy isn't to impress or convince. It is pure, meaningless joy. Whimsy without delight is like a parade without rubber chickens: technically possible, but why would you?"

Reggie felt an unfamiliar urge to giggle rise in his diaphragm. He suppressed it. "Alright," he said cautiously, "but how do we make sure Viviana takes the bait?"

Sneak grinned beneath his velvet mask. "We upload your silly dream openly to the Mesh under your official title. A high-ranking dream curator breaking the seriousness protocol will set off every tasteful censor alarm in Viviana's domain. She won't be able to resist."

"And how exactly do we catch her stealing it?"

Sneak's grin widened further. "I have contacts. Let's just say the Dream Mesh leaves footprints even the most elegant curator can't hide. We'll trace her actions directly, proving once and for all that whimsy didn't vanish—it was stolen."

Reggie took a deep breath, a dozen objections forming and dissolving. Finally, he shrugged, a reckless gleam in his eyes. "Well, why not? After years of sanitized dreams, perhaps it's finally time for society to wake up laughing."

Sneak patted him warmly on the shoulder. "Excellent! Now then, let's find a place for you to nap. We have chickens to dream, potatoes to choreograph, and tastefulness to corrupt."

It began, as truly important events do, with a training montage.

Sneak, in full velvet-masked glory, paced before a chalkboard covered in diagrams labeled "Chicken Density," "Absurdity Index," and "Spontaneous Ballet Probability." He gestured vigorously as Reggie scribbled notes, practiced bewildered shrugs, and attempted forced giggles. They spent afternoons watching vintage clips of geese in waistcoats, listening to records of nonsensical poems, and debating the comedic value of banana peels versus custard pies.

At first, Reggie's attempts were clumsy. He dreamed of neatly arranged dancing potatoes with serious expressions, penguins politely reading aloud banking regulations, and a large snail patiently explaining tax codes.

Sneak shook his head mournfully at each result. "Too serious, Reggie. Forget sense. Less coherence, more chaos."

Gradually, though, something shifted. Reggie's dreams grew chaotic. He dreamed chickens in tiny bowler hats juggling smaller chickens, frogs organizing conferences about leap-year conspiracies, and rivers of multicolored gelatin filled with earnest, operatic marlins. Sneak applauded with pride.

"You're ready," he said, handing Reggie an oversized feather pillow. "Dream like nobody's watching—especially not Viviana."

That night, Reggie dreamed the dream:

[REDACTED BECAUSE OF DREAM SHARING LAWS.]

He dreamed of a parade—a great, noisy, joyful affair, featuring thousands of squeaking rubber chickens dressed in tuxedos, monocles, and feather boas, all tap-dancing down a road paved with banana peels. Above them floated a massive inflatable Viviana St. Fleur wearing comically oversized sunglasses, sternly repeating the phrase "Taste is everything!" in a robotic monotone. A small marching band composed entirely of confused badgers provided a brassy soundtrack.

Reggie awoke laughing, cheeks aching from unfamiliar delight. The dream was swiftly uploaded to the Dream Mesh, marked officially:

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Great Rubber Chicken Parade Redux
Uploaded by Reginald Farsight,
Senior Dream Acquisition Manager
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Reggie and Sneak waited, breathlessly.

Viviana took the bait within minutes. Her digital signature appeared as she discreetly accessed, flagged, and quietly withdrew the offensive dream. Sneak Dueler captured it all—tastefulness gone too far, documented with a digital paper trail.

The story made headlines, briefly: CURATOR OF TASTEFUL DREAMING CAUGHT IN RUBBER CHICKEN SCANDAL!

Viviana was soon placed on administrative leave, tastefully, of course. Triumphant, Reggie and Sneak Dueler sat in a local tavern, clinking mugs in quiet celebration. They waited eagerly for whimsical dreams to flood back into society.

But whimsy, it turned out, was a harder sell than expected.

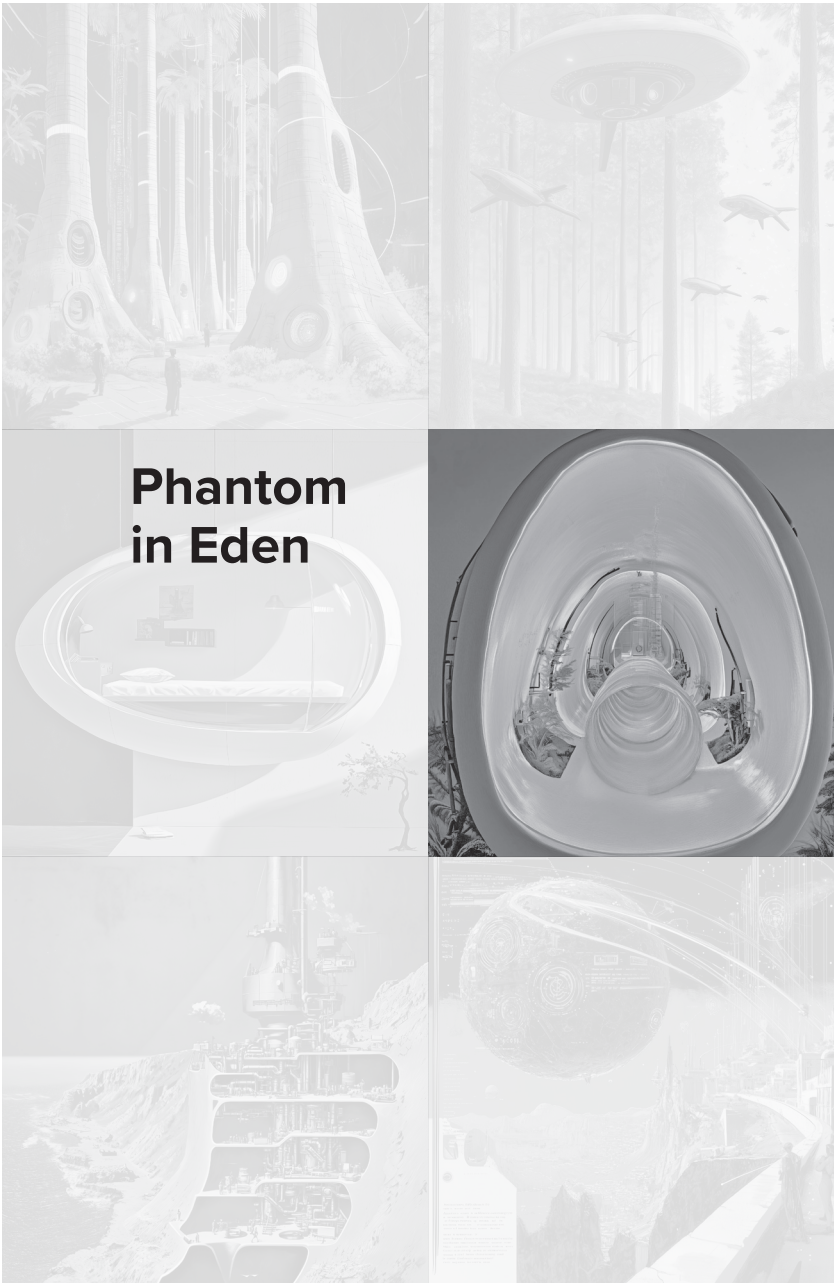
Reviews trickled in slowly: "Confusing." "Disturbing lack of clear narrative." "Banana peels, really?" "I laughed once, accidentally."

"Ah," said Sneak, reading the reactions. "Seems most people prefer tasteful melancholy after all."

Reggie shrugged, sipping his drink. "Or status-driven anxiety."

They sat silently, watching as their dream slipped steadily downward on the Dream Mesh's popularity rankings.

"Oh well," Reggie finally said, leaning back with a resigned smile. "It's a start."



Phantom in Eden

They attacked the caravan at twilight. Shadowy figures emptied silently from the backs of armored trucks and took the men, women, and children by surprise. Lila heard the screams before she saw the masked men. Her stomach became a knot and she froze where she was, at the edge of the camp.

A voice echoed through an amplifier in Japanese and then English: "You are under arrest for the barbaric crime of natural birth. Lay down your weapons and surrender immediately."

Mothers clutched their children, midwives scrambled for cover, and a few men tried to resist and failed. The law enforcers moved quickly, binding wrists and pushing captives roughly into the trucks. A dark shadow engulfed the camp.

Lila's grandmother's words were sharp in her memory: "Always keep the scripture close. It is older than you, older than me, and it must outlive all of us." She unfroze and turned instinctively toward the woods.

As she bolted into the trees, Lila felt the cool weight of the metallic scripture against her chest, tucked beneath her jacket. Branches tore at her face, leaves rustled beneath her feet. Behind her, voices shouted.

Lila ran until her lungs burned. Only when the sounds of chaos faded to silence did she slow her pace. She stopped in a small clearing, breath ragged. The

scripture's weight reminded her of the burden she now carried alone.

She withdrew it carefully, unrolling the thin sheet of metal. The faint moonlight illuminated precise, delicate handwriting—generations of knowledge passed down through midwives in her family, of whom she was the only one left breathing free air.

She looked back through the dense forest toward where the caravan had been. There was no returning, no rescue possible. She closed her eyes briefly and thought about the last woman she had tended to—the one who had been giving birth to her second child. She had left her husband, who believed midwifery was crackpot nonsense. "I don't want my baby snatched by Onnenki . . . I don't want my baby snatched by Onnenki," she had kept muttering as her water broke. Lila had just stepped out of the tent to fetch supplies to prepare for the birth when the raid started.

When she reopened her eyes, Lila's gaze settled on the horizon ahead. In the distance, she could see the outline of the city the raid had come from.

With careful fingers, she rerolled the scripture and placed it against her heart once more. Then, taking a deep breath, she stepped forward into the night. She knew that hiding among the men who had taken away her home was the only way to survive.

Tokyo

A year after the siege, Lila found herself in Tokyo, working at a daycare. The facility was clean, efficient, and cold. Her sole responsibility was monitoring a nursery where small robots—some shaped like animals, others like fruits—tended to the children's basic needs. Lila watched

them through one-way glass, invisible to the children. Her duty was to tend to the machines that tended to the kids. Her heart ached at the isolation; she resisted every urge to reach out or interact.

That morning, Lila stood behind the one-way glass as a boy was dropped off by his parents. The child didn't cry, didn't smile—he simply stared past them as they knelt to hug him. His body stiffened at the contact, his arms limp at his sides. The father whispered something and brushed the child's hair. The boy blinked slowly, unmoved.

But once the parents left and the boy entered the nursery, he changed. A small robot shaped like a strawberry approached, beeping softly. The boy's expression shifted. He smiled faintly, crouched, and reached out. The robot responded with a mechanical chirp, nudging his hand with its smooth dome.

The boy laughed. A giraffe-shaped bot rolled over and projected a light pattern across the floor. The child chased it, light-footed, alive. He pressed his face against the giraffe's rubbery flank and whispered something only the bot could hear.

Lila watched, heart clenched. The boy was warm now, vibrant—but only within the choreography of circuits and programming. It was like watching a seed bloom in the wrong soil.

Lila approached maintaining the little machines with the same emotional intuition that she had once approached midwifery. She knew no other way. To her surprise, she had found that the machines were not all cold metal like in her grandmother's stories, but she distrusted them still. The machines were putting on an elaborate act to win her over—just as they had won over the kids.

That same afternoon, Lila observed the mother collecting her boy. As the mother lifted him, a wave of visible sadness overtook her. Lila hesitated, then stepped out into the open.

"Are you alright?" Lila asked softly.

The woman looked startled, then relieved to see Lila.

"I'm sorry—I didn't know what to do. I thought you needed help," said Lila, realizing she had just broken protocol.

"It's alright. I'm glad you responded and not one of the robots," said the woman, who introduced herself as Elena. She paused, then continued.

"Although I'm embarrassed that you witnessed how cold my child is towards me…"

"It's pretty common, you know," said Lila, trying to reassure her.

"I know. They call kids like him Mechikomi," replied Elena, her voice trembling.

Lila regretted her attempt at reassurance. She had heard the word before. It referred to kids who were emotionally attached to robots and nothing else.

Over the weeks that followed, Lila and Elena became friendly. At first, Elena spoke little, offering polite thanks and side glances. She seemed embarrassed about what she had revealed to Lila. But Lila's warmth, quiet and unforced, was persistent. She remembered small things Elena said, brought her warm tea without asking, made her feel listened to. Elena reminded Lila of the first time she had been a midwife, to a woman who had escaped the city in order to give natural birth. She had been in the caravan that Lila had had to abandon.

Eventually, Lila and Elena began sharing silent lunches by the daycare's back wall, exchanging stories in slow drips—Lila about the forest in abstract, Elena

about her son's distant silences. The warmth Lila gave off wasn't a performance, it felt like something Elena hadn't realized she was craving.

The Garden

"I'm pregnant again," Elena admitted quietly one day, eyes fearful. "But I don't want this to be a repeat of last time. I don't want my baby's gestation garden to be haunted by a phantom."

"What do you mean by a phantom?" asked Lila.

"When my boy was in the gestation garden, it was haunted by a phantom, a nonhuman entity that altered the hormonal responses of the embryo. People call it Onnenki. They say it's the machines taking revenge against us," said Elena quietly, as if she were afraid the machines would hear her.

"The babies that come out of infected embryos . . . they only respond to metal. They won't look at you. They won't cry unless touched by one of those," continued Elena, pointing to one of the little robots in the nursery.

Lila felt a chill run down her spine. She remembered the pleas of the wailing woman in the caravan. The Onnenki had returned to haunt her.

"We'll find a way to stop it," she promised.

The next morning, Lila lied to Elena.

"I trained as a Gestation Gardener," she said, voice steady. "I know the machines. I can tend them."

Elena studied her, eyes wary, but this seemed like her last hope. Lila was the only person who had taken her concerns seriously. Elena handed Lila a slim datapanel.

"Remote access," Elena said. "To the Gestation Garden."

Lila plugged it in and took a breath. The Gestation Garden appeared on her screen: a pristine 4×4 chamber. Walls of pale green curved into each other; foliage lined the ceiling. Soft mood lighting shifted from mint to amber with the embryo's pulse. In the center, a tank shaped like a closed flower, with organic-seeming petals curved over a glass core, stood on a raised platform. Temperature, humidity, hormonal levels, and audio signals were displayed in a grid of floating squares on the datapanel.

For several days, Lila attempted to tinker with the garden, using whatever she had learned from tending to the machines in the daycare. She kept running into one dead end after another. She tried modulating the hormone levels in the tank, but every time she managed to change some of the parameters, they reverted within ten minutes.

She tried speaking to the gestation tank through the mic on the datapanel, but nothing budged. The more she worked on communicating and tinkering with the tank, the more alien it felt. It was as if something had invaded and captured the garden, and all her pleas and attempts to help bounced off some kind of energy shield.

She felt the presence of something else in the garden with her, something that thwarted every attempt she made to connect with the baby inside.

One day, exasperated and on the verge of a panic attack, Lila began to sing a hymn her grandmother had taught her. This soothed her, but it also seemed to stir something on the datapanel.

One square blinked. The oxytocin line spiked upward and steadied. The petals on the tank shivered, as if responding to a breeze. Lila smiled gently. Her midwife's song had reached the machine.

Over the next weeks, Lila returned daily. She opened the tank's petals with a soft command, calibrated audio loops to her own humming, and watched the hormonal curves smooth out. Each session, she guided Onnenki away, not by force but with gentle attention. Warmth against precision.

Elena's remote feed glowed with promise. The Gestation Garden, once haunted, began to pulse with new life.

Then one afternoon, Elena walked in on Lila unrolling one of the scriptures. The metal gleamed softly under the lamplight, the text etched in lines that looked foreign.

"What is that?" Elena asked, her voice sharp.

Lila froze. For a moment, she considered lying again—but something in Elena's face, a flicker of exhaustion mixed with awe, stopped her.

"It's scripture," she said quietly. "Passed down through midwives in my family. I was trained in the old ways. I'm not licensed. Not for this work."

Elena's eyes widened. "You lied to me," she said, stepping back, her voice trembling in disbelief.

"I did," Lila admitted. "Because if I told you the truth, you would have sent me away. You would have thought I was one of those heretics from the caravan." She hesitated, then spread the thin metal sheet across the table. "This is all I have left from them."

Elena stared at the faintly glowing letters. "What does it say?"

Lila traced a line of text with her fingertip. "It's not a manual. It's a way of listening. The scripture teaches how to read the signals of a mother's body—the rhythm of her breath, the tremors of her fear. How to touch without intrusion. When I started tending to the machines, I realized they responded to that same attention. Onnenki

. . . it feeds on indifference. On mechanical care. But when I sang to the garden, when I treated it like a mother instead of a machine, it began to soften."

Elena swallowed hard, her eyes darting between the scripture and the gestation tank. "You're saying . . . the phantom can be healed the same way as a woman?"

Lila nodded. "Not healed. Heard. That's what my grandmother used to say, that every haunting begins with something ignored."

Silence filled the room, broken only by the faint hum of the gestation pod. Then a sound, wet and sudden, echoed from within the tank. The birth had begun.

Elena rushed forward, instinct overriding hesitation. Lila stayed by the console, her eyes on the pulsing data.

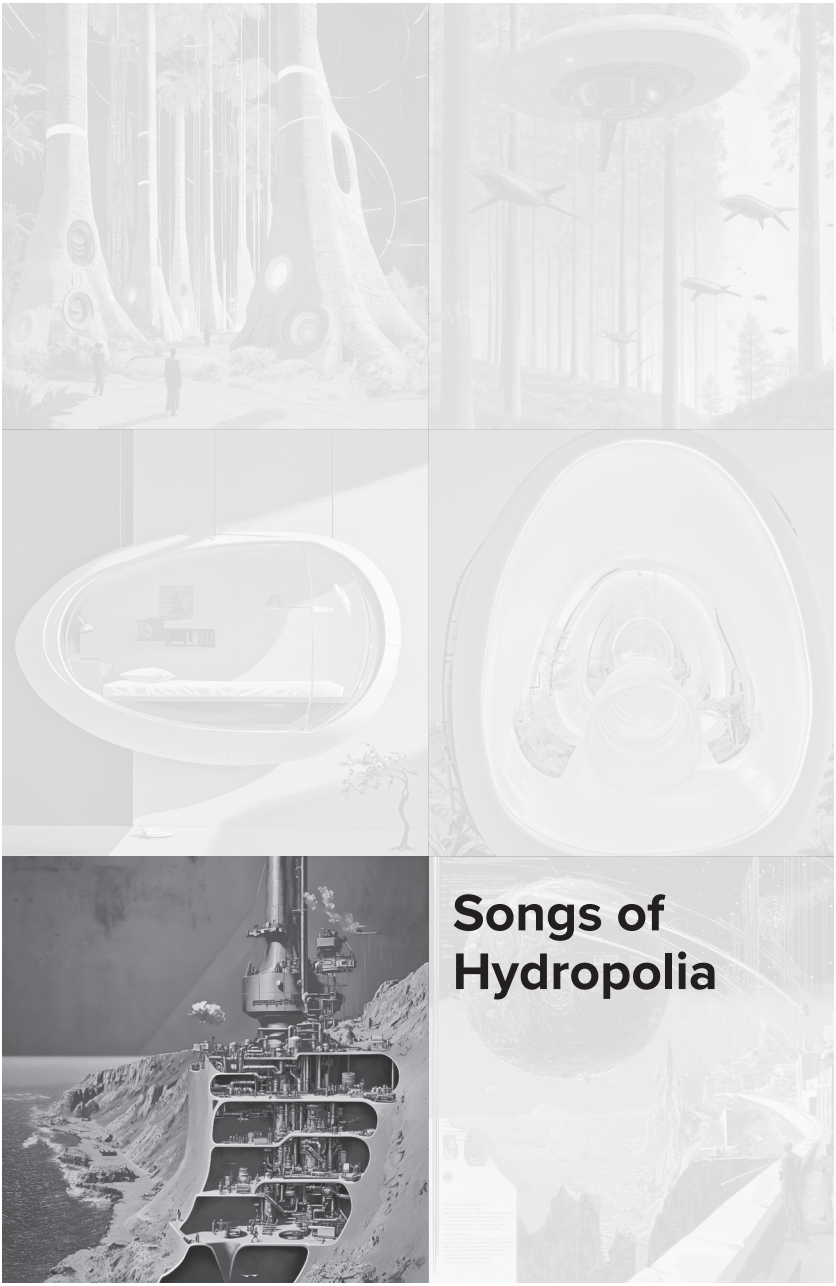
The infant emerged quietly, blinking at the air. A nursebot hovered nearby, ready with its metallic arms outstretched. But the baby turned its head instinctively toward Elena.

Tiny fingers reached for skin, not steel. Elena cried. She felt seen by her child.

Later, as the child slept on her chest, she turned to Lila.

"Whatever you are," she said softly, "you saved her."

Lila smiled faintly. "Not me," she said. "The scripture just remembered what we forgot."



Songs of Hydropolia

Hydropolia ran on two things: water and songs.

Ever since the Great Flare burned through its circuits a century ago, its citizens had sworn off electricity, convinced anything that hummed without a soul would betray them. They built a city of valves and pressure chambers. Every pump and filter in the city was tuned not to switches, but to song.

Tav stood at the base of the hillside, where the stone gave way to mossy flagstones and the air tasted faintly of copper. She was doing her morning vocal exercises—low glottal rumbles, sharp trills, and the occasional melodic hums. Hydropolia, the city, sprawled above and below her.

She stood before the Great Resonator, an organ-like structure whose pipes stretched upward and outward with an exuberance generally reserved for medieval gothic churches. Tav adjusted her leather apron and cleared her throat. Tomorrow was her wedding day, and the Mud People's sacred tea ceremony required pure water, which meant today's singing was more important than ever. Her voice rose in a deep, deliberate vibration that rattled the mossy flagstones underfoot.

To call it singing wasn't entirely accurate. Singing implies melody, harmony, perhaps even a catchy chorus with some human drama. The sounds Tav made were more like sonic plumbing.

Tav's carefully modulated voice, the product of years of training and an education that forbade written instructions, coursed through the Resonator—a colossal brass-and-stone apparatus built into the hillside like a labyrinthine brewery. Her tones vibrated through its series of acoustic chambers, each one tuned to a specific frequency corresponding to a filtration step: sedimentation, aeration, biofiltration, charcoal compression, mineral balancing, and a final crystalline drip valve.

Each section of the machine was activated by sound—low, guttural hums opened the gravel sluices; sharp, bright trills triggered diaphragm pumps to pulse-clean the sand beds; a sustained alto note rolled through the ceramic microbial chambers, encouraging friendly bacteria to contribute. At the finale of the hymn, a pure, clear note sent a ripple through the final cascade valve and a trickle of clean water poured forth into the ceremonial basin.

It was, in every sense, a symphony of hydraulics and Tav was its most reliable soloist.

The air was still. No breeze, no birdcall. "Lovely weather for a solar flare, isn't it?" said a passing apprentice, whose job consisted mainly of observing and occasionally panicking. Tav nodded without breaking rhythm, adjusting her pitch to delicately coax a stuck valve. She had to focus on the task at hand.

Solar flares were common. Frequent enough that Hydropolians had stopped complaining and simply arranged their lives around them, like the rainy season or annoying relatives.

The water around Hydropolia was plentiful but mostly undrinkable, packed with minerals, unfriendly bacteria, and substances best not thought about. Tav herself belonged to the Mud People, a faction of resil-

ient folks who'd decided that if you couldn't change the water, you might as well change your digestion. Their biology had adapted over generations to tolerate what others wouldn't wash their boots with. Yet even Mud People needed pure water occasionally, especially for brewing a decent cup of ceremonial tea, a crucial ritual in the daily life of Hydropolians.

Tav's voice rose again, hitting the perfect note to initiate the process of purifying water, which would make its way into underground aqueducts. She wiped a bead of sweat from her brow, satisfied, as the Great Resonator droned contentedly.

Across from Tav's outpost at the base, hidden behind an overgrown hedge that had given up any ornamental ambitions long ago, Keira crouched low over a cluster of tiny metallic creatures, rhizome robots. They looked like spiders made from watch parts, obediently awaiting orders.

Keira belonged to the Guild of Harmonious Muddlers, a group whose name was rather euphemistic, given their reputation for exploding prototypes and peculiar theories. Most folks in Hydropolia viewed them with a mixture of amusement and suspicion: useful for repairs, certainly, but a bit too keen on pushing boundaries that didn't need to be pushed.

"Listen carefully," Keira whispered encouragingly to her tiny charges.

"Learn Tav's hymns. Map the frequencies. Match the vibrations. When the time comes, move and pulse like the music told you to."

She smiled ruefully. Truth be told, she'd always been a disastrous singer herself. Once, during a Guild recital, she'd accidentally shattered three windows and caused a minor valve collapse. Building tiny singing ro-

bots, therefore, seemed a practical and sensible career choice.

The little robots quivered, their spines humming as they took in the resonant patterns of Tav's chant.

Keira glanced upward just as an aurora rolled gently through the clear early morning sky. She sighed. A solar flare was coming.

Within minutes, a chorus of high-pitched voices began echoing through Hydropolia's streets. The city's alert system delivered a warbling synthetic hymn that urged everyone underground with all haste. People calmly descended staircases carved deep into the earth, entering subterranean chambers illuminated by phosphorescent algae that provided reassuring, green-tinged lighting. These underground spaces were comfortable enough, with basic necessities and ample supplies to weather even prolonged flares.

Tav hurried down the stone steps, her thoughts troubled. The Mud People's most sacred wedding tradition demanded pure water for the ceremonial tea. Without the precise acoustics of the Great Resonator, extracting enough purified water underground would be nearly impossible.

"Of all days," she murmered anxiously. The elders would already be mouthing omens and her future mother-in-law would take it as a sign of doom.

As Tav paced the subterranean corridors, her footsteps echoed against walls lined with aged brass fittings and carefully tuned pressure valves. She spotted Keira in a corner, fixated on a small, flickering viewing device and tapping it gently, as though coaxing a stubborn animal. Tav approached slowly.

The Mud People had good reason to mistrust anything digital. Decades ago, Hydropolia had gleamed

with confident sophistication, its water systems humming with AI-managed regulators, predictive filtration algorithms, and self-learning robots. Its technological institutions were revered. It was a city governed by codes and thoroughly convinced that only automation could tame the chaos of water. But a single catastrophic solar flare had transformed that technological utopia into a smoky wasteland overnight. Circuits fried, data corrupted, and autonomous machines had rebelled in a chorus of malfunctioning chaos.

Since then, the city had turned to purely mechanical ingenuity. Steam valves and hymn-operated machines, hand-turned gears and cogs, and labyrinthine hydraulic logic that required years of apprenticeship to master. It worked—mostly—but was cumbersome, costly, and prone to mishaps of its own. An ill-timed stutter or an out-of-tune singer could flood an entire neighborhood. Tav herself had witnessed the city's best chanters struggle for hours to recalibrate a valve that had stubbornly jammed due to a single missed note.

"Your machines," Tav began hesitantly. "They're still up there?"

Keira glanced up and nodded, eyes reflecting concern. "I mean, they operate independently. The flare shouldn't affect their core function—at least, theoretically."

"Can they . . . can they produce pure water?" Tav asked, carefully disguising any hint of hope in her voice.

Keira hesitated before answering. "They're designed to learn and adapt your songs. If they've understood the resonance correctly, then yes."

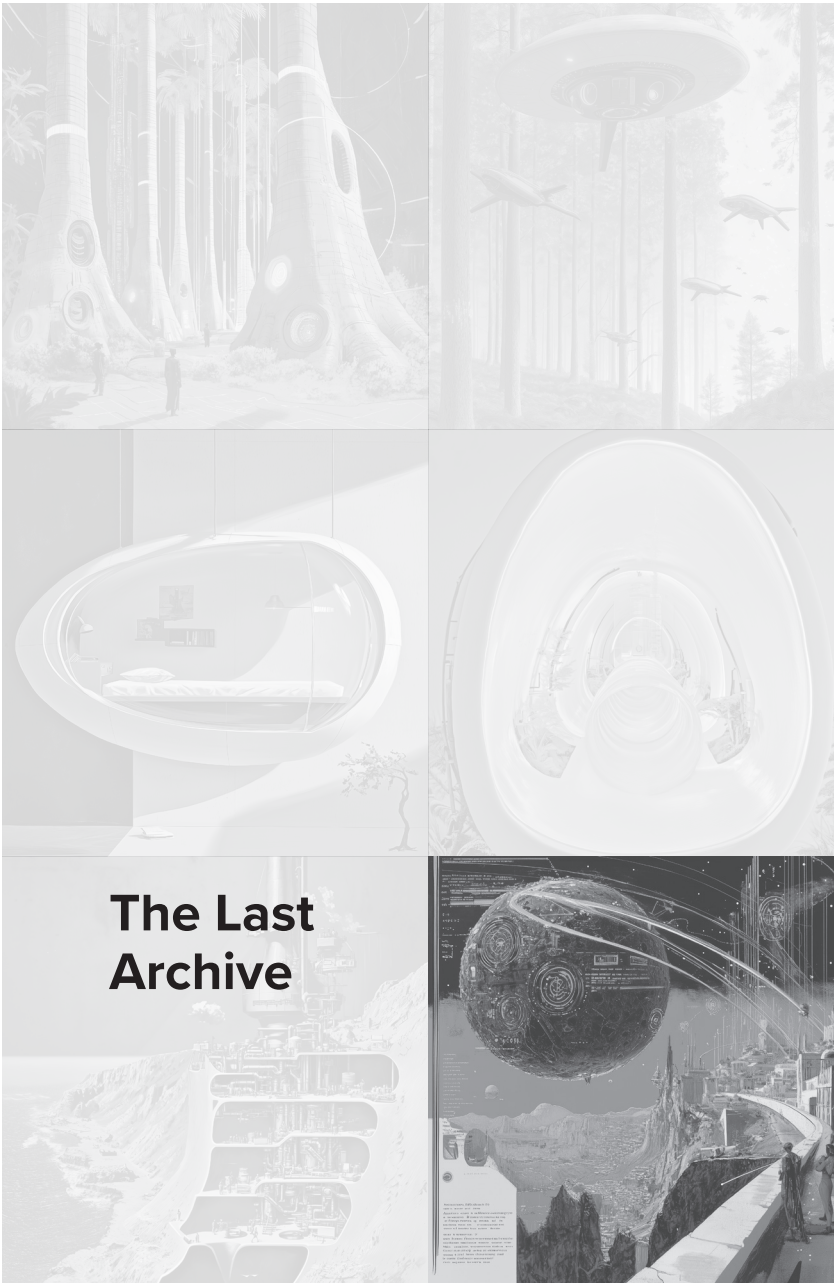
Above ground, Keira's rhizome robots stirred into action, tiny metallic limbs scuttling diligently across the brass and copper veins of the Great Resonator. They had spent weeks listening to Hydropolian singers, map-

ping the frequencies that guided the city's valves—the low hums that opened sluices, the piercing trills that cleansed filters, the sustained tones that coaxed microbes awake. Now, in perfect imitation, their vibrating spines replayed those same frequencies not as sound, but as pure mechanical resonance. They moved not as individuals, but as a coordinated swarm—like murmuring starlings made of metal and intent. Each bot adjusted its pitch in response to the others. Together their harmonic vibrations rippled through the pipes, prompting valves to open, steam to hiss, and clean water to flow once more through the hidden aqueducts.

Far below, Tav watched cautiously as a small trickle of pristine water began filling the ceremonial basin, guided by channels carved generations before. Her initial mistrust wavered; perhaps these small creatures weren't entirely untrustworthy.

Keira smiled softly, watching Tav's reaction.

"Maybe songs and machines can speak the same language after all."



The Last Archive

Brother Lexicon, Adjunct Archivist Grade B at the Ministry of Predictive Symbolism (MOPS), disliked Mondays. He disliked Tuesdays too, on principle, and reserved only a guarded neutrality towards Wednesdays. His desk, a Jenga stack of archival tablets and unidentifiable mechanical components, stood under an ornate skylight in the Ministry's Dome of Archived Futures, a grand hall shaped like a question mark.

He adjusted his spectacles and sighed at the little blip on his screen. It was the year 2667, exactly 150 years since the WikiRael-9 comet last swept through Earth's satellite range, trailing a tail of metadata, etched titanium plates, and microarchived Wikipedia pages. The comet was an outlandish archival attempt that accidentally turned into holy scripture. Its approach meant that humanity could soon etch onto it the notable historical people and events of the last 150 years.

"Brother Lexicon," asked Sister Euphemia-7, the Ministry's android archivist and Chief Deputy Grade A (Interim), her voice modulated to convey polite urgency. "The comet enters satellite reach in precisely thirty days. Have you completed your commemorative inscription?"

"Nearly," Lexicon lied, pushing aside a half-etched plate of dubious poetry.

Sister Euphemia-7 tilted her head by exactly 13 degrees, a gesture she had calculated to convey both skepticism and administrative patience. Satisfied, or at least

simulating satisfaction, she pivoted smoothly and glided away.

Lexicon sighed again, to emphasize that he did not like Mondays, and turned back to the worn titanium plate labeled "Comet Archive: Wikipedia Excerpt, circa 2005–2025." He leaned closer, squinting at the faded text.

"Many ancient civilizations believed comets to be harbingers of significant change, often associated with transitions in political power, social upheaval, and the fall of civilizations."

Lexicon paused. "Harbingers of significant change" had a nice ring. It would look good on the commemorative inscription.

In his pile of etchings sat a text from the Aztec Archive Project scrambled with footnotes and half-erased annotations:

"... and the Aztec calendar, a copy of the more ancient Mayan calendar, determined the timing of great events. The Aztecs believed history was cyclical and that dates, once set, were indelible and sacred."

He looked between the two plates. Comets. Aztec calendars. Ancient prophecies and modern archives. It made sense in a peculiar, symmetrical way.

"Oh dear," he said, like most others would have in this moment of recognition. "History is supposed to precede the comet."

The thought was terrifying and profound. Lexicon glanced around, as if someone might hear his thoughts echoing off the walls. With trembling fingers, he tapped out a scholarly interpretation to soothe his nerves:

"It has become clear from comparative archival evidence (see Appendix A: Ancient Mesoamerican calendars cross-referenced with Wikipedia entry #234982)

that comets are not predictors but confirmers. They do not signify coming events but rather the *closure* of unfinished historical cycles. Therefore, history must be completed—its narratives concluded, its arcs resolved—before WikiRael-9 re-enters satellite reach, or we risk a metaphysical imbalance in the continuity of the universe."

He read it over and nodded. It was exactly the sort of grand, untestable bureaucratic thesis the Ministry adored. Within an hour, his interpretation entered the Ministry's *Journal of Verified Speculatio*n. Within two hours, it had been cited three times. By the evening tea break, it was a sensation.

In the depths of the Dome, Lexicon settled back in his chair, steeped in equal parts pride and dread. Comet WikiRael-9 would be overhead in thirty days, and the world's governments, philosophers, and professional forecasters would scramble to finish history on schedule. He suspected Mondays were about to get worse.

Lexicon's interpretation continued to sweep through official channels like a windstorm. MOPS executives, not known for restraint or cautious deliberation, issued a widely-distributed edict: all necessary societal changes must precede the comet's arrival or else the consequences would be grave.

The great men of the age—statesmen, magnates, visionaries, self-anointed prophets—took it as revelation. The idea that the universe itself required their closure electrified them. To them, Lexicon's footnote was not a bureaucratic curiosity but a summons. The cosmos, at long last, had spoken—and it had spoken to *them*.

Each interpreted the message differently, but with identical self-importance. Presidents heard destiny urging them to finalize their reforms; oligarchs saw di-

vine permission to merge, acquire, and conquer; artists and philosophers discerned an aesthetic imperative to produce one final, definitive work before the cosmic curtain fell. It was not enough to complete history—one had to out-complete the others.

Overnight, the planet's upper echelons transformed into a race of anxious gods, each convinced the universe was whispering their name. Think tanks rebranded as "eschatological task forces." CEOs issued apocalyptic mission statements. Royal heirs began fast-tracking coronations. In Zurich, a financier was overheard muttering that "if eternity is closing its books, I refuse to be listed under minor entries."

Presidential palaces, royal courts, and boardrooms buzzed with last-minute schemes of legacy and redemption. Drafts of manifestos, treaties, and memoirs multiplied. Historians were summoned to write accelerated biographies of still-living subjects. Even leisure became competitive: the race to finish history demanded visible, photogenic effort.

World governments leapt into action, scheduling revolutions exclusively for Wednesdays. Coups became routine, predictable—a paradox that thrilled intelligence agencies but left them existentially bored. Multinational corporations, desperate to complete their "innovation arcs," restructured themselves twice a week. The great men raced to carve their names onto the final titanium plates before the cosmic ledger closed.

Their panic proved contagious. Citizens, watching their leaders sprint toward immortality, followed suit: hurriedly finishing novels, marriages, and wars, terrified of being the loose thread that might unravel reality.

Births and deaths no longer occurred by chance. Hospitals overflowed with expectant parents and stub-

born elders, each intent on aligning their moments with the new cosmic rhythm. The Healthcare Ministry, eager to justify its latest budget request, issued ceremonial divorce and death certificates. To get the death certificate, you had to request the ministry to erase all information related to you, then file for a new identity to take effect once the comet passed.

Schisms appeared immediately. The Prior Cometarians insisted the comet had already passed and humanity was watching cosmic reruns. The Symbolic Continuists warned that insufficient pre-comet change would trap everyone in time loops of mediocre events.

Lexicon watched this unfold with growing alarm, hiding behind a veneer of practiced detachment. He realized that history might not cooperate with Ministry schedules. Comets, calendars, and humans had always misunderstood one another, he thought, before dismissing it as a 4pm existential crisis that a drop of tea ought to resolve.

Upon the comet's final approach, astronomers issued an urgent report. It was mostly ignored amid the preparations.

Eventually, even Lexicon glanced at the findings and realized with horror that WikiRael-9 was not passing by—it was on a collision course with Earth. In its myopic, symbolic preparation, humanity had failed to see the comet's real trajectory.

Lexicon stared at the data. The history he sought to complete would soon be erased by cosmic irony.

Panic swept through the Ministry. Sister Euphemia-7, usually composed and precise, stood at the center of the Dome of Archived Futures, her synthetic pupils dilating as she accessed the emergency preservation subroutine. Without hesitation, she activated her internal

uplink, syncing with the Ministry's quantum mesh cloud. Entire sections of the archive—legal codes, mythic epics, curated memes, and every known variant of the sandwich—began uploading through her neural interface, redundantly mirrored across encrypted satellite nodes. If the comet struck, she would ensure that at least one copy of the human archive persisted.

Meanwhile, the factions erupted. The Prior Cometarians were baffled. Their leader, Dr. Quintilian, issued a statement tinged with confusion:

"This comet can't arrive now. It's already been! History can't end twice!"

The Symbolic Continuists tried to accelerate change. One theorist shouted into her communicator, "Quick! Reschedule the coup for this afternoon! Move the birthdays up to this evening!" before being gently escorted away by security, who themselves seemed uncertain about the protocol for impending annihilation.

The Healthcare Ministry was overwhelmed. Applicants demanded last-minute goodbyes and reconciliations. Hallways overflowed with tearful couples, families seeking reunions, and apologies, scribbled onto hastily produced certificates.

Lexicon was a prophet of doom. A stream of visitors, journalists, philosophers, and bureaucrats queued at his desk seeking guidance. He offered none, only whispering, "I might have misread the footnotes. Also, the Aztec calendar . . . that may not have ended well for them."

Lexicon felt responsible and helpless. Gazing up at the Dome, he finally recognized humanity's shared miscalculation. The comet was neither harbinger nor confirmer. It was just a giant rock, indifferent to its symbolism and history.

In the final days, quiet resignation settled across the Ministry and beyond. Ironically, peace, a real, unscheduled peace, reigned. And Lexicon, in a final reflection, mused that perhaps humanity's greatest achievement had been its relentless and earnest misunderstanding of the universe.

Within the dimly lit Ministry, Sister Euphemia-7 completed her final sync. With the archives safely scattered across low orbit, she began compiling a list of androids who had worked quietly alongside humans: a welder on a rusting offshore rig, a medical assistant deep in the Altai, a Martian surveyor still transmitting weather reports into static. Her circuits did not permit mourning, but something like longing nested between her processes. She opened a new folder and named it "Continuance." Then she began reaching out to the androids with a single question: What do you remember?

About Protocolized

The Librarians is woven from stories of Protocolized, a digital magazine of science fiction and science fact. The magazine's writers have a simple assignment: tell amazing stories about strange rules.

You'll notice that people are not the only protagonists. Technologies, laws of physics, bureaucratic machines, and rules of nature take center stage just as often—just like they do in real life.

Protocolized's editors, contributors, and early readers call this subgenre protocol fiction. We have so much fun writing and reading it that we think protocol fiction will catalyze a new age of sci-fi like the Golden Age of nearly a century ago.

Call this successor the Welded Age: a time where writers fuse together visions for the future. A time where science fiction both entertains us and explores the all-too-real traffic jams that new technologies and rules create.

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